The significance of this failed attempt at reform is that it meant that the Foreign Office remained relatively the same department in the post-war period that it had been prior to 1914. In fact, a large proportion of those who served in the Foreign Office and Diplomatic Service before the First World War continued to do so after the conflict.[55] Many of the key players that will feature in this book had long-standing experience of foreign service: Sir Lancelot Oliphant, Sir Percy Loraine and Sir Percy Cox to name a few. Balfour, Curzon and Hardinge were three of the most influential figures within the British government in the first half of the twentieth century. All three had cut their teeth on foreign affairs years before the outbreak of the First World War. Not only did these men share an educational and class background, but the preparation and training for their work in the Foreign Office resulted in an almost homogeneous view of the nature of Britain's foreign affairs. The seasoned diplomat and author, Harold Nicolson, termed this mode of thought 'the Foreign Office mind', while another contemporary referred to the department as 'the brotherhood'.[56] Importantly, those men who made up 'the brotherhood' in the early years of the twentieth century adhered to a certain way of thinking about Britain's foreign relations which has earned them the label the 'Edwardians'.[57] As opposed to the 'Victorians', who eschewed alliances with other powers, the Edwardians championed the concept of a 'balance of power'.[58] Eyre Crowe's 1907 memorandum on Britain's relations with France and Germany has come to be seen as the classic exposition of this doctrine.[59] The fact that the paper was still being read in the 1920s by Foreign Office officials is a prime example of how pre-1914 concepts of foreign affairs were carried into the post-1918 period.[60] That Crowe himself remained a prominent figure within the department after the First World War personified this continuity in the Edwardians' way of thinking.

There has long been a belief/understanding that continuity is important in international affairs and therefore that foreign policy should be above party politics. It is this continuity which allows foreign policy makers to take decisions based on the long-term issues rather than the short-term repercussions. What is more, in Britain, the wealth of knowledge and experience which Foreign Office officials and diplomats carry with them is useful when it comes to tackling the big issues of foreign policy. However, the risk of such uniformity in personnel is that it can leave the Foreign